

Deciding something must be wrong with you for still being single

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Being single this long doesn't prove anything is wrong with you. People do judge single people more harshly as the age goes up, and plenty of people are single without choosing it.

THE GOAL

You're getting through the question without apologizing for the answer. Give something short and plain, like 'Still single,' and **stop there**.

CHECKLIST

Someone just asked about your love life.

- ☐ Give a short, plain answer and **stop there**: no joke, no apology, no explanation, just something like 'Still single' said plainly.
- ☐ If the same person has asked before, say so plainly: 'We've talked about this, I'll let you know if anything changes.'
- ☐ If they push with 'why,' turn it around: 'Why do you ask?' Then stay quiet and let them answer first.
- ☐ If they push past a 'why do you ask' of your own, name it once: this reaction has a name, and it isn't about you.
- ☐ If they still won't drop it, close it flatly and change the subject yourself: 'I'm not going to keep explaining this.'
- ☐ If they offer advice you didn't ask for, say thanks once and move on: 'Thanks, I've got it covered,' then change the subject.
- ☐ If they compare you to someone else's timeline, say plainly it's not the same and pick a new subject yourself.
- ☐ Once the topic moves on, follow it: ask about whatever they bring up next and stay there.
- ☐ Before you leave the conversation, tell yourself the plain fact once: this is a bias other people carry, not a flaw in you.
- ☐ Before you leave the conversation, remind yourself plenty of single people are in the exact same spot, not by choice either.
- ☐ If a specific comment is still stuck in your head, name exactly what was said, not what you assume they meant by it.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 People's ratings of single people get harsher as the imagined age goes up, from 25 to 40.
- 2 About a third of singles, across fourteen countries, are single involuntarily: **they want a partner** and haven't found one.
- 3 Quietly expecting to be rejected was linked to whether your relationship lasted a year later, the study found, for men and women alike, regardless of how strong it started out.

The judgment is a stereotype, not evidence about you

KNOW

People's ratings of single people get harsher as the imagined age goes up, from 25 to 40.

The study rated singles on traits like being immature and badly adjusted, and the scores rose as the age attached to them rose. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

When people read you as immature, badly adjusted or self-centered for being single, that's a documented stereotype talking, not you: the gap people imagine between single and married people is large, but the real gap is small.

Those traits are what people assume about single people: your relationship status never produced them. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Housing agents overwhelmingly chose married applicants over identical unmarried ones, in one study, and admitted marital status was the reason.

In that study, 61 percent of agents preferred the married couple and said it was because of the marriage. [Source 1](#)

What you're comparing yourself against doesn't hold up

DON'T

Don't take 'married people are happier' as proof something's missing in your life. The real gap researchers find is small, and even that may exist mainly because **happier, healthier people are likelier to marry** to begin with, not the other way round.

Married and single people who get compared were never randomly assigned, so happier people choosing marriage explains the gap just as well. [Source 2](#)

DON'T

You owe nobody an explanation for being single this long. The question assumes everyone eventually marries.

A lot of people never marry, so there's no deadline being missed here, and no timeline you owe anyone. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

About a third of singles, across fourteen countries, are single involuntarily: **they want a partner** and haven't found one.

Not having found someone yet is **one of the most ordinary reasons** people end up single, as common as any other. [Source 4](#)

What to do with the question, and with the fear itself

SAY

When someone asks why you're still single, a response researcher Bella DePaulo recommends is handing it back: "Why do you ask?"

DePaulo, who studies single life, lists this among her own recommended responses to the question. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

Quietly expecting to be rejected was linked to whether your relationship lasted a year later, the study found, for men and women alike, regardless of how strong it started out.

Researchers tracked couples for a year and found rejection fears were linked to breakup even after ruling out how strong the relationship already was. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If you just relax and stop looking, love will find you, so if it hasn't, you must be doing it wrong.

ACTUALLY

That's not how it happens for most people anymore. Active, deliberate searching, especially through online dating, **overtaken meeting by chance** through friends as the most common way couples meet back in 2013. [Source 6](#)

Sources

- <https://www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/happy-singlehood/202201/discrimination-against-singles>
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6. https://web.stanford.edu/~mrosenfe/Rosenfeld_et_al_Disintermediating_Friends.pdf

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Being single at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)